and practices of his devotional *Shri Vaishnava* cult were the true expression of the orthodox *Vedic* religion represented by the ***Brahma-Sutras***, the ***Upanishads***, the ***Bhagavad Gita*** and the ***Dharmashastra*** literature. His most important works are the commentary on the ***Brahma-Sutras***, called the *Shri Bhashya*, the commentary on the ***Bhagavad Gita*** and the 'Compendium of the Meaning of the Scriptures' (*Vedarthasamgraha*).

While the *Advaitins* view the world including individual experiencers and agents as an illusion concealing an impersonal Absolute that is inactive, featureless consciousness, Ramanuja sees it as really created by a personal God who invites our loving response. He believes that there are three types of realities: a personal divine life called *Vishnu Narayana*; individual souls which are always aware of their enduring identities whether they be subject to ***karma*** or enjoying the supernatural state that is exempt from ***karma***; and physical bodies and objects occupying the material environment. Souls and matter depend upon God: a physical body is an entity only if there is a soul associated with it. Interpreting some passages in the ***Upanishads***, which refer to a soul who is the inner self and guide (*antaryamin*) of individual selves, he articulates the relation between God and the world of souls and matter in a soul–body model (***sharira-shariri-bhava***). He accepts the ***satkaryavada*** theory of causation according to which effects pre-exist in their underlying cause before becoming entities. ***Brahman*** is called the cause of the universe when its body is in its causal mode, 'containing' all entities in potential form. ***Brahman*** is in its effected mode when selves and matter are manifested. Theorists belonging to the ***Bheda-abheda-vada*** tradition thought that creation is a transformation of God (*Brahma-parinama-vada*). For *Ramanuja* this implied too close an association between God and the cosmos. His view is that the creation of the